From Vignette Spreadsheet to Word Questionnaire

This guide walks through Mail Merge in Word: connecting the Excel file that holds the ten vignette decks, inserting each vignette sentence as a dynamic field, previewing the rendered text, and exporting one PDF questionnaire per deck.

What this guide covers

- Importing the Excel workbook as the mail-merge data source.
- Inserting each vignette sentence as a dynamic «merge field» in the questionnaire template.
- Using Preview Results to check the rendered wording before finalizing.
- Stepping through all 10 decks and saving each as its own PDF.

Step 1. Open the Mailings ribbon

The Mailings tab holds every tool needed for this workflow, grouped left to right in the order we'll use them: Start Mail Merge, Select Recipients, Write & Insert Fields, Preview Results, and Finish & Merge. We will use Select Recipients to connect the Excel file, Insert Merge Field to place the vignette text, and Preview Results to check each deck before exporting.

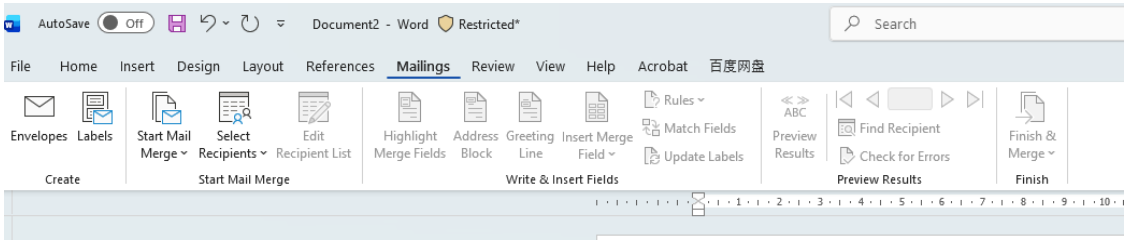


Figure 1. The Mailings ribbon in Word.

Step 2. Connect the Excel file

Click Select Recipients and choose “Use an Existing List…” rather than typing a new list or pulling from Outlook contacts. This points the merge at the Excel workbook exported from R, which already contains one row per deck and one column per vignette sentence.

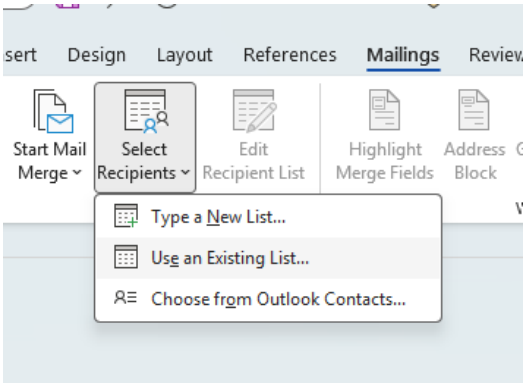


Figure 2. Select Recipients → Use an Existing List.

Step 3. Choose the worksheet

Word then asks which sheet in the workbook to use as the data source. Select the sheet that holds the vignette decks and keep “First row of data contains column headers” checked, so the column names (deck, sentence_1_01, sentence_2_01, …) become the available merge field names.

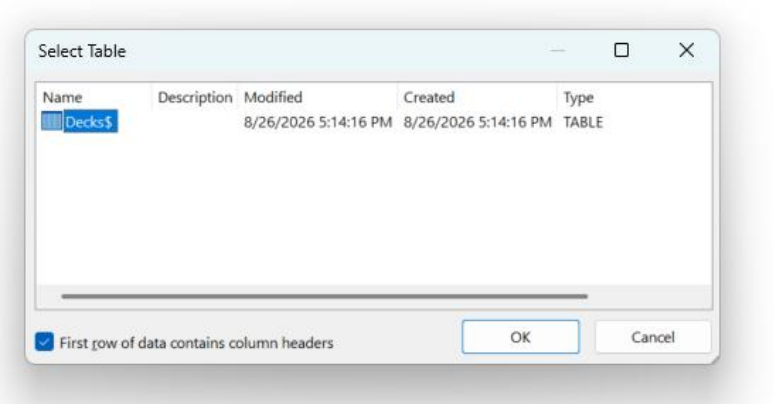


Figure 3. Selecting the worksheet that holds the vignette decks.

Step 4. Insert the dynamic fields

With the data source connected, place the cursor in the questionnaire template and use Insert Merge Field to add each vignette sentence. Every column from Excel appears in this list; insert sentence_1_01, sentence_2_01, sentence_3_01, and sentence_4_01 into the first vignette's paragraph, and repeat the same pattern for the remaining vignettes on the page. The rating question and scale below each vignette stay as plain static text, since that wording never changes.

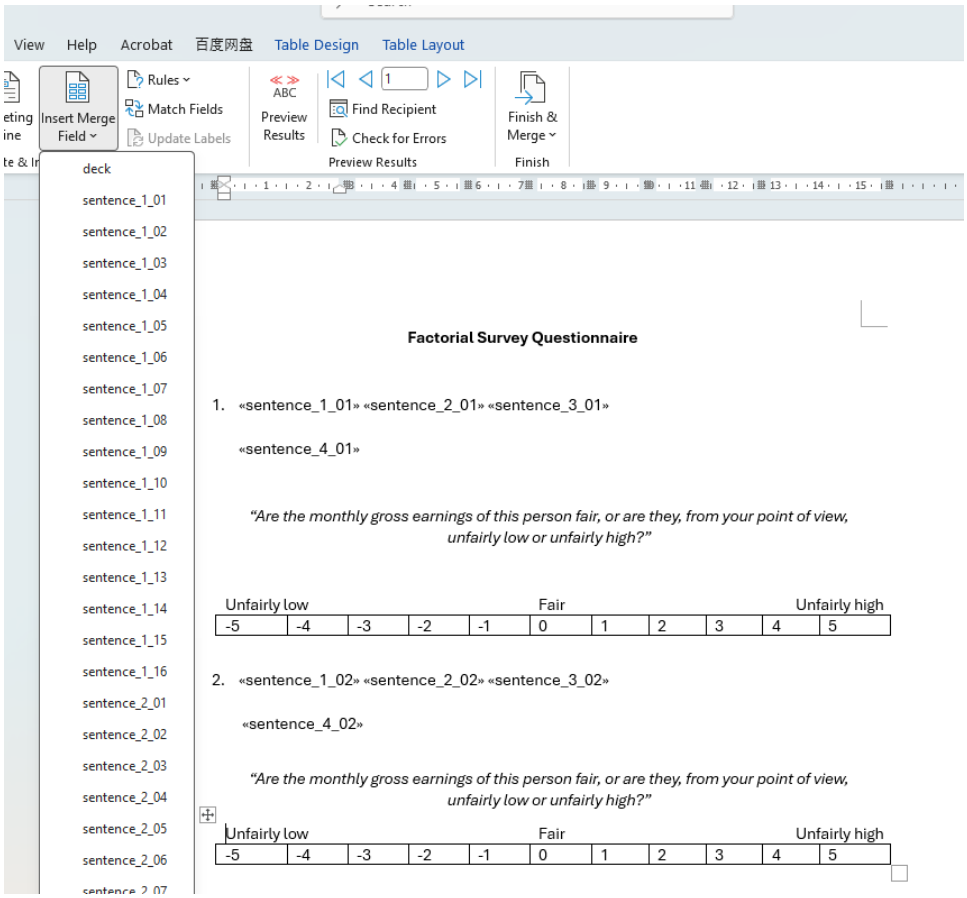


Figure 4. Inserting merge fields into the questionnaire template.

Step 5. Preview the first deck

Turn on Preview Results (record box shows "1") to swap the field codes for actual text. Read through the rendered vignette carefully — check wording, punctuation, and that numbers such as monetary amounts display the way they should — before moving on.

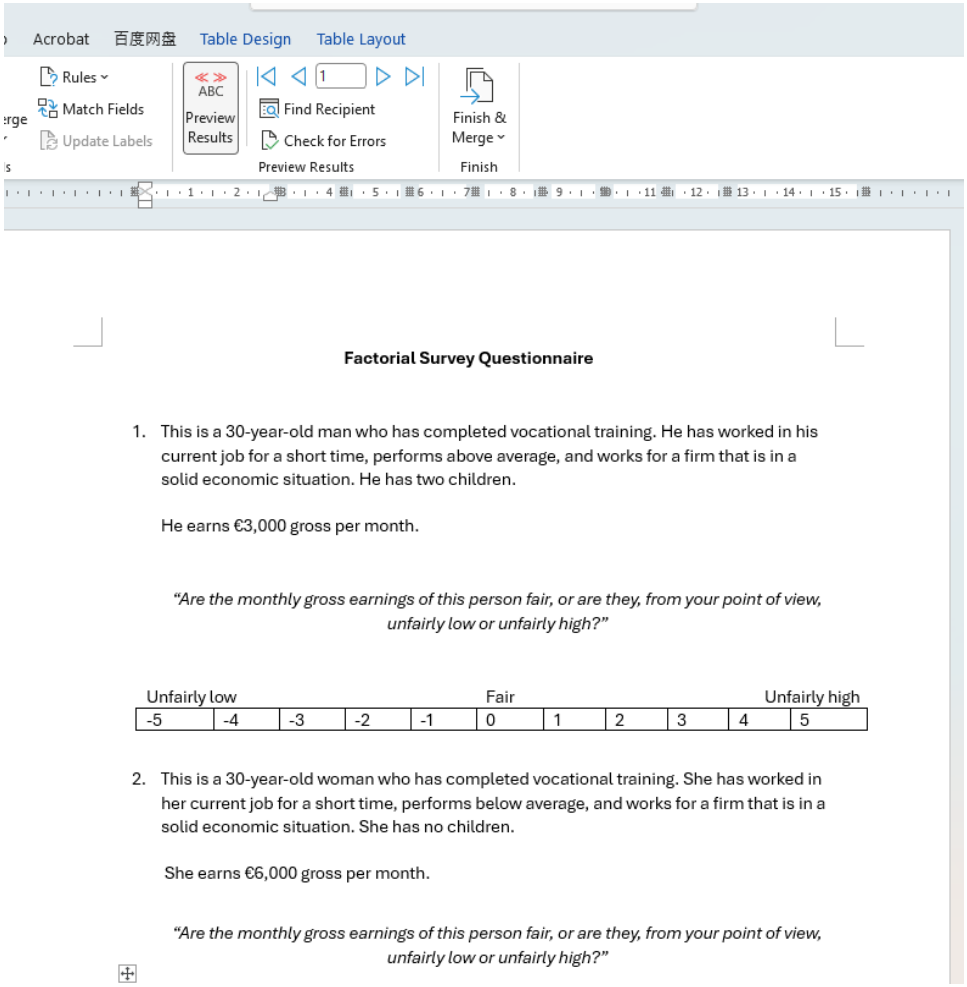


Figure 5. Preview Results showing deck 1.

Step 6. Step through all 10 decks

Use the navigation arrows, or type a record number directly into the box, to move through every deck. Here the record box has been set to "10", showing the last deck. Check each one the same way as the first before exporting.

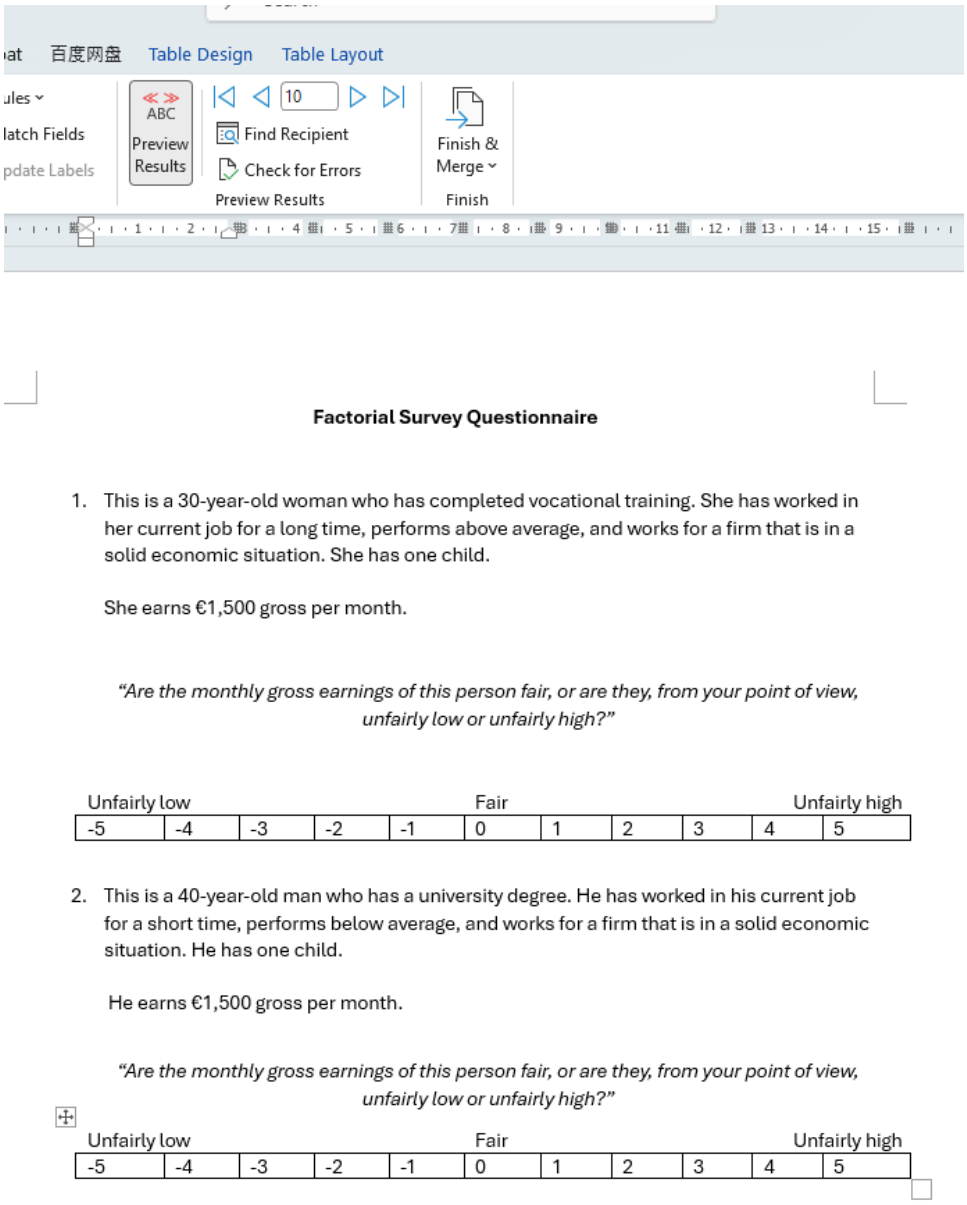


Figure 6. Preview Results showing deck 10, the final deck.

Step 7. Export each deck as a PDF

With Preview Results still on, navigate to a given deck and use File → Print → Save as PDF (or print to a PDF printer) to store that single, fully rendered questionnaire. Repeat for each of the 10 decks in turn, so the result is ten separate PDF files — one per deck — ready to field.